

Code Review and Deployment Guidelines

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Every change to a production service goes through a pull request. Direct pushes to main are blocked at the repository level for everyone, including the CTO, and there is no emergency bypass. An emergency fix follows the same path with a single reviewer and a shorter description, which in practice costs about four minutes; the absence of a bypass mechanism is deliberate, because a bypass that exists is a bypass that gets used at exactly the moment when review matters most.

Review requirements

Change	Approvals	Reviewer constraint
Default, any repository	1	Anyone other than the author
relay-core repository	2	At least one reviewer who has been on the rotation for that service
Migration files, any repository	1 plus platform	Platform team review is additional, not substitutive
Public API contract change	2	Compatibility impact stated explicitly in the description
Documentation only	1	Anyone, including a first-week hire

Table 1. Approval requirements by change type.

The review service level is one business day. A pull request open for two business days without review can be escalated in the engineering channel, and escalating is expected rather than tolerated. Reviewers are expected to be specific: a comment stating that something feels wrong, without a proposed alternative or a concrete concern, is not a review and the author may reasonably ask for it to be replaced with one. Approving a pull request you do not understand is a worse failure than admitting you do not understand it, and the second of those has no consequences attached whatsoever.

Deploys

Deploys are continuous. Merging to main deploys to staging automatically, and to production once the staging smoke suite passes. There is no release train, no manual approval gate, and no deploy window, with a single exception: no deploys to relay-core after 14:00 EET on Fridays, or at any time on the day before a public holiday in Estonia. This restriction applies to relay-core only and not to other repositories, and it exists because both regional incidents in the last eighteen months were discovered by people who were about to stop working for the day. It is not a statement about Friday deploys in general.

Feature flags

Feature flags are the default for anything user visible. Flags older than 60 days appear on a weekly report and are expected to be either removed or promoted into configuration, and the report is reviewed in the engineering weekly rather than sent into a channel to be ignored. A feature flag is not a substitute for a migration plan, and a flag that guards a change with a database migration behind it protects nothing, since the migration has already run.

Rollbacks

Rollbacks are always acceptable and never require discussion. Roll back first, understand second. An engineer who rolls back somebody else's change without asking them is doing the right thing, and the expectation is only that they say so in the engineering channel immediately afterwards. Nobody at Nordvane has ever been

criticised for an unnecessary rollback, and the Atlas incident included a rollback of an unrelated deploy that had no effect on the outcome and cost thirty-five minutes; that rollback is still considered to have been the correct decision with the information available at the time.